

drives, in fact anything that requires power and needs protection.

2. If any device has a power rating given in watts, take that figure and multiply by 1.4. This gives you the device's VA rating.

3. Check the amps and volts ratings of the devices you have listed. To get a VA rating, multiply the amps by the volts.

4. Add the VA ratings of all your devices to get a grand total.

5. Multiply this total by 1.2 if you want to factor in one more device later.

6. Make sure that whatever type of UPS you opt for, your VA total should not exceed the VA rating of the UPS. It is always recommended to buy a UPS with a higher VA rating than your cumulative VA rating.

Before you set up...

SoHo businessmen would typically face two scenarios when it comes to UPS implementation—whether to connect one big UPS to centrally control all PCs at the same time, or to have individual UPS for every PC. Why only PCs? Because connecting a printer (especially if it is a laser printer) to a battery output socket on the UPS will cause considerable power drain, which could instead be used for another PC.

Based on our power calculation earlier, a modest eight-



Before you sign the cheque...

- ❑ Check for the warranty offered. Some UPS manufacturers provide model specific warranties.
- ❑ Pay attention to the manufacturer's support agreement. Do they have a replacement policy? Do they have trained support personnel? What happens in case the UPS goes kaput? Do they have a policy of providing standby UPS machines? Ask your vendor these questions before you buy.
- ❑ What software do you get to monitor the UPS? How effective is it? Does it automatically shut down

PCs if it is low on battery? Does it continuously monitor and give you a status report of voltage conditions and situations like brownouts? Questions like these would put to rest the doubts about the software solution provided with the UPS.

❑ The best possible situation is to test the UPS at your location. Ask the manufacturer to arrange for a demo that will simulate your work conditions and check if the claims of the manufacturer match the performance of the UPS.



with a printer and scanner, considered with a backup time of around 10 minutes, you will need to opt for a UPS that provides at least 700VA of power and will cost you about Rs 5,000 and will vary for the different options that we mentioned above.

And some thoughts for the road...

SoHo or home users can easily opt for solutions mentioned above. There are several UPS brands available in the market, and quite a few local brands have earned themselves a good reputation. Nevertheless, make sure you go through the product brochure and take some time to understand the ups and downs of the product. What may look good at first sight, may turn out to be bad oversight on your part.

No matter what option you pick—centralised or decentralised—depending on your budget and the priority and importance that you assign to your machines, make an investment that will last you through the years. ■

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person SoHo outfit would require at least a 5kVA UPS considering eight Pentium 4 PCs with 17-inch monitors.

This done, check the UPS type you consider to be the best option in your budget. We would recommend spending a little more and get a good UPS rather than go for an 'in-the-budget' solution. A centralised solution would cost you somewhere between Rs 75,000 to Rs 1 lakh. This solution could provide you a battery backup time of about 20 minutes.

For a single PC home solution



Multifunctionality

Some UPS systems provide features that let you connect a mobile charger or have an inbuilt flashlight that can come in handy in case of power-cuts. Other features that you can probably look for when buying an UPS is if it can let you attach additional batteries, and if they can be hot swapped at a time of emergency. Also look for connectivity options such as serial or USB, power monitoring and voltage conditioning options.

How UPSes Work?

